The Tale of the Three Brothers

(Harry Potter & the Deathly Hallows, C. 21)

By J.K. Rowling

HARRY: The Deathly Hallows?

XENO: You haven't heard of them? I assume that you are familiar with 'The Tale of the Three Brothers'? . . .I have a copy somewhere . . .

He glanced vaguely around the room, at the piles of parchment and books, but Hermione said,

HERMIONE: I've got a copy right here.

And she pulled out The Tales of Beedle the Bard from the small, beaded bag.

XENO: Well then, why don't you read it out aloud? Much the best way to make sure we all understand.

She opened the book and began to read.

INTRODUCTION

It is said that whomever holds all three of the Deathly Hallows will become the Master of Death!

But what does it mean to become the "Master of Death?" – Does it mean that you have complete control over death

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itself, or that by accepting and not fearing death, you have the ultimate control?

Albus Dumbledore once spoke these words: "The true master does not seek to run away from Death. He accepts that he must die, and understands that there are far, far worse things in the living world than dying."

And so the legend comes to pass in the final book of the Harry Potter series: Harry Potter and the Death Hallows. This is The Tale of the Three Brothers by J.K. Rowling.

HERMIONE: There were once three brothers who were traveling along a lonely, winding road at twilight – In time, the brothers reached a river too deep to wade through and too dangerous to swim across. However, these brothers were learned in the magical arts, and so they simply waved their wands and made a bridge appear across the treacherous water. They were halfway across it when they found their path blocked by a hooded figure. And Death spoke to them –

He was angry that he had been cheated out of the three new victims, for travelers usually drowned in the river. But Death was cunning. He pretended to congratulate the three brothers upon their magic, and

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said that each had earned a prize for having been clever enough to evade him.

So the oldest brother, who was a combative man, asked for a wand more powerful than any in existence: a wand that must always win duels for its owner, a wand worthy of a wizard who had conquered Death! So Death crossed to an elder tree on the banks of the river, fashioned a wand from a branch that hung there, and gave it to the oldest brother.

Then the second brother, who was an arrogant man, decided that he wanted to humiliate Death still further, and asked for the power to recall others from Death. So Death picked up a stone from the riverbank and gave it to the second brother, and told him that the stone would have the power to bring back the dead.

And then Death asked the third and youngest brother what he would like. The youngest brother was the humblest and also the wisest of the brothers, and he did not trust Death. So he asked for something that would enable him to go forth from that place without being followed by Death. And Death, most unwillingly,

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handed over his own Cloak of Invisibility.

Then Death stood aside and allowed the three brothers to continue on their way, and they did so talking with wonder of the adventure they had had and admiring Death's gifts.

In due course the brothers separated, each for his own destination.

The first brother traveled on for a week more, and reaching a distant village, sought out a fellow wizard with whom he had a quarrel. Naturally, with the Elder Wand as his weapon, he could not fail to win the duel that followed. Leaving his enemy dead upon the floor the oldest brother proceeded to an inn, where he boasted loudly of the powerful wand he had snatched from Death himself, and of how it made him invincible.

That very night, another wizard crept upon the oldest brother as he lay, wine-sodden upon his bed. The thief took the wand and for good measure, slit the oldest brother's throat.

And so Death took the first brother for his own.

Meanwhile, the second brother journeyed to his

own home, where he lived alone. Here he took out the stone that had the power to recall the dead, and turned it thrice in his hand. To his amazement and his delight, the figure of the girl he had once hoped to marry, before her untimely death, appeared at once before him.

Yet she was sad and cold, separated from him as by a veil. Though she had returned to the mortal world, she did not truly belong there and suffered. Finally the second brother, driven mad with hopeless longing, killed himself so as to truly join her.

And so Death took the second brother from his own.

But though Death searched for the third brother for many years, he was never able to find him. It was only when he had attained a great age that the youngest brother finally took off the Cloak of Invisibility and gave it to his son. And then he greeted Death as an old friend, and went with him gladly, and, equals, they departed this life.

Hermione closed the book. It was a moment or two before Xeno seemed to realize that she had

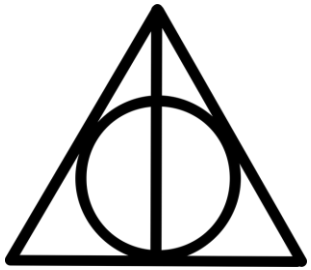
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stopped reading; then he withdrew his gaze from the window and said:

XENO: Well, there you are. Those are the Deathly Hallows.

He picked up a quill from a packed table at his elbow, and pulled a torn piece of parchment from between more books.

XENO: The Elder Wand ***(drawing a strait vertical line on the parchment)*** The Resurrection Stone ***(adding a circle on top of the line).*** The Cloak of Invisibility ***(enclosing both line and circle in a triangle).*** Together -- the Deathly Hallows.



HERMIONE: But there's no mention of the words 'Deathly Hallows' in the story,

XENO: ***(smugly)*** Well, of course not, That is a children's tale, told to amuse rather than to instruct.

Those of us who understand these matters, however, recognize that the ancient story refers to three objects, or Hallows, which, if united, will make the possessor master of Death.

There was a short silence in which Xeno glanced out of the window.

RON: When you say 'master of Death'

XENO: ***(waving his hand)*** Master. Conqueror. Vanquisher . . . whichever term you prefer.

HERMIONE: ***(slowly)*** But then . . . do you mean . . . that you believe these objects – these Hallows – really exist?

XENO: ***(raising his eyebrows)*** Well, of course.

HERMIONE: We all know that there are such things as Invisibility Cloaks. They are rare, but they exist. But –"

XENO: Ah, but the Third Hallow is a true Cloak of Invisibility, Miss Granger! I mean to say, it is not a traveling cloak imbued with a Disillusionment Charm, or carrying a Bedazzling Hex, or else woven from Demiguise hair, which will hide one initially but fade with the years until it turns opaque. We are talking about a cloak that really and truly renders the wearer completely invisible,

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and endures eternally, giving constant and impenetrable concealment, no matter what spells are cast at it. How many cloaks have you ever seen like that, Miss Granger?"

Hermione opened her mouth to answer, then closed it again, looking more confused than ever. She, Harry and Ron glanced at one another, and Harry knew that they were all thinking the same thing. It so happened that a cloak exactly like the one Xeno had just described was in the room with them at that very moment.

XENO: Exactly. None of you have ever seen such a thing. The possessor would be immeasurably rich, would he not?

HERMIONE: All right. Say the Cloak existed. . . what about that stone? The thing you call the Resurrection Stone? How can that be real?"

XENO: Prove that is not.

HERMIONE: ***(Outraged)*** But that's – I'm sorry, but that's completely ridiculous! How can I possibly prove it doesn't exist? Do you expect me to get hold of – of all the pebbles in the world and test them? I mean, you

could claim that anything's real if the only basis for believing in it is that nobody's proved it doesn't exist!"

XENO: Yes, you could. I am glad to see that you are opening your mind a little.

HARRY: So the Elder Wand, you think that exists too?

XENO: Oh, well, in that case there is endless evidence. The Elder Wand is the Hallow that is most easily traced, because of the way in which it passes from hand to hand. The possessor of the wand must capture it from its previous owner, if he is to be truly master of it. Surely you have heard of the way the wand came to Egbert the Egregious, after his slaughter of Emeric the Evil? Of how Godelot died in his own cellar after his son, Hereward, took the wand from him? Of the dreadful Loxias, who took the wand from Baraabas Deverill, whom he had killed? The bloody trail of the Elder Wand is splattered across the pages of Wizarding history.

RON: So where do you think the Elder Wand is now?

XENO: Alas, who knows? History, alas, does not tell us.

HERMIONE: ***(after a pause)*** Does the Peverell family have anything to do with the Deathly Hallows?

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XENO: ***(taken aback)*** You have been misleading me, young woman! I thought you were new to the Hallows Quest! Many believe that the Peverells have everything – everything! – to do with the Hallows! [that] the three brothers in the story were actually the three Peverell brothers, Antioch, Cadmus and Ignotus! That they were the original owners of the Hallows! . . . ***(takes tray and exits down a spiral staircase, saying)*** You will stay for dinner?

Harry waited until they could hear Xeno moving about in the kitchen downstairs before speaking.

HARRY: ***(to Hermione)*** What do you think?

HERMIONE: ***(wearily)*** Oh, Harry, it's a pile of utter rubbish. This can't be what the sign really means. This must just be his weird take on it. What a waste of time.

HARRY: ***(to Ron)*** You didn't believe it either?

RON: Nah, that story's just one of those things you tell kids to teach them lessons, isn't it? Don't go looking for trouble, don't go pick fights, don't go messing around with stuff that's best left alone! Just keep your head down, mind your own business, and you'll be okay.

HERMIONE: I think you're right, It's just a morality tale, it's obvious which gift is best, which one you'd choose –

The three of them spoke at the same time: Hermione said, "the Cloak," Ron said, "the Wand," and Harry said, "the Stone." They looked at each other, half surprised, half amused.

RON: ***(to Hermoine)*** You're supposed to say the Cloak, but you wouldn't need to be invisible if you had the wand. An unbeatable wand, Hermione, come on!

HARRY: We've already got an Invisibility Cloak.

HERMIONE: And it's helped us rather a lot, in case you hadn't noticed! Whereas the wand would be bound to attract trouble—

RON: Only if you shouted about it. As long as you kept your trap shut –

HERMIONE: ***(skeptically)*** Yes, but could you keep your trap shut? You know the only true thing he said to us was that there have been stories about extra-powerful wands for hundreds of years. The Deathstick, the Wand of Destiny, they crop up under different names through the centuries, usually in the possession of some Dark wizard who's boasting about them.

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HARRY: But how do you know that those wands -- the Deathstick, and the Wand of Destiny -- aren't the same want, surfacing over the centuries under different names?"

RON: What if they're all really the Elder Wand, made by Death? ***(To Harry)*** So why would you take the stone?

HARRY: "Well, if you could bring people back, we could have Dumbledore . . . my parents. . . But according to Beedle the Bard, they wouldn't want to come back, would they?

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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